

At a time when most of her peers were enjoying college life, 18-year-old Shreya Ghoshal was balancing academics with a busy career in music. This girl from a small town, Rawatbhata in Rajasthan, who came to Mumbai when she was 13, is Bollywood's leading playback singer today. She had her first brush with the industry in 2000 at the age of 16, when director Sanjay Leela Bhansali spotted her on *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa* on Zee TV and offered her five songs in *Devdas*. *Bairi piya* won her the National Award. She hasn't looked back since.

Ghoshal's training began at the age of four. Since she could not get the best possible formal training in her home town, her father Bishwajit decided to send her to Kota. There she trained in Hindustani classical music under Maheshchandra Sharma. At the age of 10, she participated in the *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa* contest for the first time where music director Kalyanji advised her parents to move to Mumbai. There, she trained under him for 18 months and under Mukta Bhide in classical music. "I attribute my success to all my gurus, especially Kalyanji," she says.

From Indian folk to world beats, she has an ear for melodious music. "I am hungry for music. I look for a melodic soul in every kind of music," she says. Of all the music composers, A.R. Rahman is her favourite since "he is the only composer who comes up with something new every time". Despite her soaring popularity, solidified with the solo at the Shreya Ghoshal night at the Sydney Opera House last year, she has her feet placed firmly on the ground. And her nose buried in the latest Jhumpa Lahiri.

by Nikita Jain

"NOT EVERYTHING GOES ACCORDING YOUR WISH, SO don't fear failure. I enjoy music and love singing. My fan-following gives me the greatest high."

SHREYA GHOSHAL,
PLAYBACK SINGER, 25

Role Model

Her father Bishwajit Ghoshal, a scientist. He is the most sensitive person she has known. She wants to borrow his experiences and learn from them.